A couple of weeks before that, I was in a meeting with Dhawan when Seshan walked in with the news that the French had accepted the contract. It was expected, and we shook hands with each other. An excited Seshan, then had this to say: the French were also willing to give India a cryogenic rocket engine. Seshan, an IAS officer, was not a scientist, but he often understood—sometimes better than my scientist colleagues—the importance of being futuristic when it came to rocket science.

'They say they will give us the cryo engine for just Rs 1 crore,' Seshan told Dhawan.

I knew about this offer, for SEP had indicated this to me a few times. I kept out of it since I wanted Dhawan's focus on the liquid rocket engine deal. Seshan probably chose the wrong occasion to say this, for I thought Dhawan was either in one of those rare moments of foul mood, or he was too relieved that the French deal has come through, and was not in a great hurry to think of another round of negotiations till this one was done.

'Seshan, this is technology,' said Dhawan. 'You please focus on administration.'

Seshan, a man of considerable and justified ego, was too proud to even argue.

'Yes sir,' he said, and sat through the meeting in silence.

Dhawan was soon his jovial self, and had evidently forgotten the snub he had given Seshan. About half-an-hour into the meeting, discussing a concept, Dhawan turned to Seshan.

'What do you think of it, Seshan?' he asked.

'It's technology sir,' Seshan retorted. 'I will focus on administration.'

He delivered that sentence poker-faced, no emotion in his voice. Dhawan and I exchanged a quick glance and got on with the discussion. I believe Seshan must have felt satisfied, if not happy, that the meeting in which his suggestion was dismissed also presented him with an opportunity to get even with the chairman of ISRO.

History proved that Dhawan was making a big mistake by not taking forward the cryogenic deal of Rs 1 crore that Seshan had suggested. When India signed a cryogenic deal with the Russians in the early 1990s for Rs